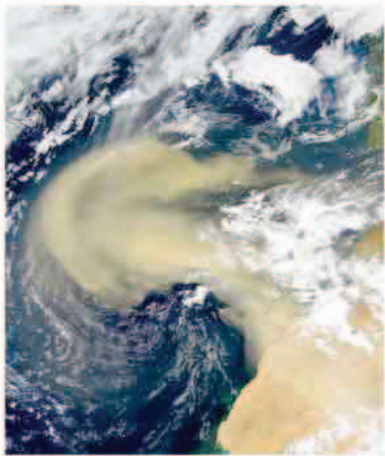




▲ SOFT SEDIMENTS

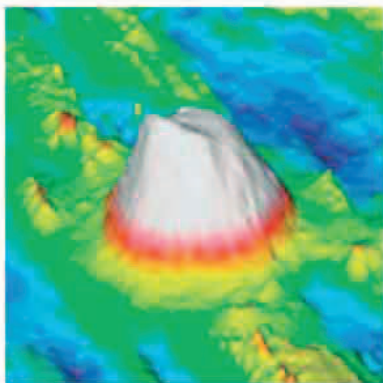
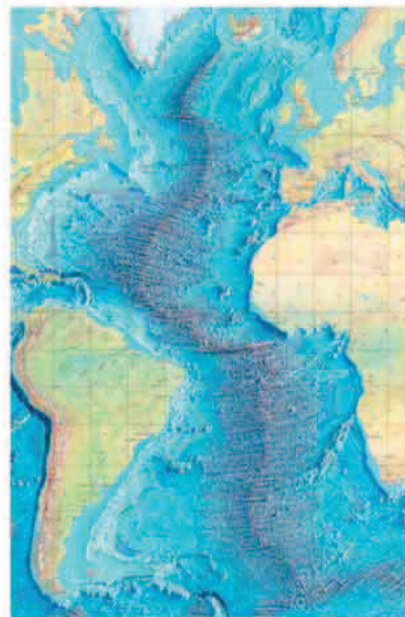
Vast areas of the deep ocean floors are covered with thick layers of soft mud and ooze, forming flat abyssal plains. Some of these soft sediments are the remains of tiny sea life. Others are made of rock particles blown over the ocean by desert storms, such as this Saharan dust storm seen from space.

SEEING THE OCEAN FLOOR

The first complete map of the ocean floor was created in the mid-20th century by American geologists Bruce Heezen and Marie Tharp, using simple depth measurements gathered from all over the world. As the map took shape, it revealed a pattern of ocean-floor features that were unknown to science. It inspired both its makers and other scientists to discover more about how these features had been formed.

► HEEZEN-THARP MAP

This graphic representation of the Mid-Atlantic Ridge on the Atlantic Ocean floor is part of the map that astounded the world.



▲ SEAMOUNT

The ocean floors are peppered with underwater mountains known as seamounts. These are nearly all extinct oceanic volcanoes, though some are still erupting. There are thousands of them in the Pacific.



▲ OCEAN TRENCH

Most ocean trenches lie on the fringes of the Pacific and in the northeast Indian Ocean. Some are more than twice as deep as the average ocean. This satellite image shows the deep trenches (dark blue) off Japan.

